

Which CFP Mascots Ruled the Internet in 2025? A Look at Online Popularity

Research Question

Every year, the College Football Playoff rankings spark endless debates about which teams are the “best.” But I wanted to flip that idea around and ask a lighter, more interesting question:

Which of the top 12 CFP teams actually had the most popular mascot during the 2025 season?

Instead of measuring wins or ESPN ratings, I looked at something different, how often people searched for these mascots online.

Source of the Data

To measure this, I used the Wikipedia Pageviews API, which tracks how many times each Wikipedia article is viewed per day. Every mascot has its own page, which makes pageviews a surprisingly good indicator of how much attention a mascot is getting.

I collected daily pageviews from August 1 through December 8, 2025, covering the entire 2025 football season.

How I Used the API

For each mascot, I built a Pageviews API URL and used R to:

1. Request the data with `httr::GET()`
2. Parse the JSON into a readable format
3. Turn it into a tidy tibble
4. Save each mascot’s data as a CSV
5. Combine everything into a single dataset for comparison

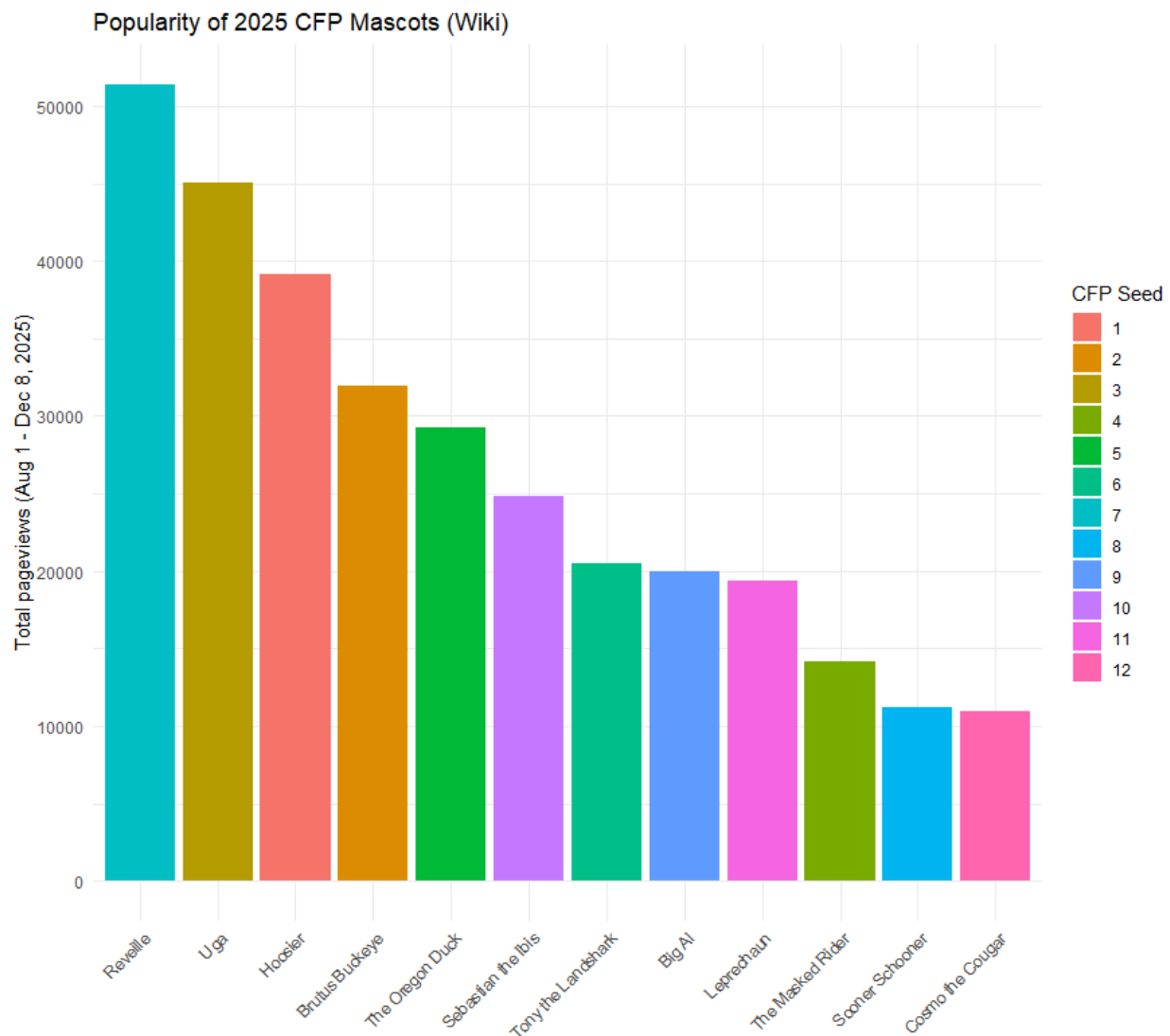
This created a clean table of dates and view counts for every mascot.

How I Answered the Question

Once I had the daily pageviews, I calculated the total views for each mascot across the season. The idea was simple:

More pageviews = more online interest.

Below is the figure summarizing total pageviews for each mascot:



What the Results Show (The Interesting Part)

The results told a fun story I didn't expect:

- **Reveille (Texas A&M)** absolutely dominated. She wasn't the #1 CFP seed, but she was the clear fan-favorite online with over 50,000 pageviews.
- **Uga (Georgia)** also pulled huge numbers, no surprise for one of the most recognizable mascots in college football.
- **Hoosier (Indiana)**, even though the Hoosiers don't have a costumed mascot, still ranked high, showing surprising interest.
- **Cosmo the Cougar**, despite being well-known to BYU fans, had some of the lowest pageviews in the field.
- Several mascots (like **Sebastian the Ibis** and **The Oregon Duck**) outperformed teams seeded above them, suggesting that mascot fame doesn't always match team performance.

This created a different kind of ranking. not a football ranking, but a popularity ranking.

Summary

Using the Wikipedia Pageviews API, I built a dataset of daily views for each CFP mascot's Wikipedia page. Summarizing these totals gave me a new angle on the 2025 CFP field: not who played the best football, but which mascots captured the most attention online. It was a fun way to turn raw API data into a story about culture, fandom, and the personalities that make college football unique.

Here's what the bracket would look like if the winner was based on mascot popularity.

